

GIREESH GV



Babus See Red Here

Ill-treated at the hands of ministers in the LDF Government, state bureaucrats line up for deputations in New Delhi

God's Own Country may be one of the world's top destinations on tourists' lists but bureaucrats here are fleeing to the Capital, seeking deputation with the Central government as they feel the heat in the Left-ruled state. They refuse to return even when the invite comes from the chief minister himself. At present 15 of Kerala's 20 seniormost IAS officers are on deputation with the Central Government, mostly on account of numerous spats with the comrades ever since the Left Democratic Front (LDF) Government came to power 15 months ago.

The most dramatic of these conflicts led to state chief secretary Lizzie Jacob opting for voluntary retirement recently, just six months before the end of her tenure. Jacob, a 1971 batch officer, chose to quit after Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan publicly accused her of keeping him in the dark about the construction of a helipad for an impending visit of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. Jacob stood her ground even after the chief minister

publically requested her to reconsider her decision. "I am touched by his magnanimity but I stand by my decision," she said.

The chief minister's next step then, of appointing Jacob's successor, led to protests from civil servants. As all the three eligible candidates of the batch of 1972 were on deputation at the Centre, next in line—P.J. Thomas, a 1973 batch officer, then principal secretary, higher education—should have been made the chief secretary. But the chief minister bypassed him as he was an accused in a corruption case. As the two officers immediately junior to Thomas were also away on deputation, the post was handed over to 1975 batch officer K.J. Mathew. This led to angry protests from the IAS Officers' Association and an angry chief minister had to give them all a dressing down.

The chief minister simultaneously requested the Prime Minister's Office to relieve at least one of the three seniormost officials, who were on deputation, for the post of chief secretary. They were Commerce Secretary G.K. Pillai, Labour Secretary Sudha Pillai, and Adviser in the Ministry of Finance Vinod Rai, all 1972 batch officers. But none took up the invitation and had Principal Adviser to the Prime Minister T.K.A. Nair telling the Kerala chief minister about the Centre's inability to spare these officers. This, coupled with widespread protest against denying Thomas the post, forced the chief minister to cancel his earlier decision and appoint Thomas as the chief secretary.

It has become almost routine for bureaucrats to shun Kerala whenever Marxists come to power. The Left governments are known to make them scapegoats. Recently, the Government suspended five forest officials including the chief wildlife warden in connection with the purchase of an ecologically fragile piece of land by the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). "The deal was in connivance with Forest Minister Benoy Viswam but the officials had to bear the brunt and Viswam went scot-free," says Leader of the Opposition Oommen Chandy. Minister for Temple Administration G. Sudhakaran went to extent of calling some officials 'dogs'. Little surprise then that IAS officers of Kerala prefer to stay away.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

THE TOP DOGS

Seniormost civil servants from Kerala who are on Central deputation

K.M. CHANDRASEKHAR Union cabinet secretary

G.K. PILLAI Commerce secretary

VINOD RAI Adviser, Union Finance Ministry

SUDHA PILLAI Labour and employment secretary

SATYANARAYANA DASH Principal adviser, Planning Commission

K. MOHANDAS Additional secretary, Union Finance Ministry

RUDRAGANGADHARAN Additional secretary, Union Ministry of Personnel

S. SUNDARESAN Additional secretary, Petroleum Ministry

MATHEW C. KUNNUNKAL Additional secretary, Petroleum Ministry

SAYAN CHATTERJEE Additional secretary, Consumer Affairs Ministry